VU AI HUB · LECTURE NOTES

Academic Writing

Year 1, April to May 2026

Written by Inaaya and shared on Notion. Original page: cheddar-wall-f3b.notion.site/3339801a93098042834eddc95e26d0b6

31th of March (WG)

Accuracy: Grammar, Vocabulary, Punctuation & Spelling

- No spelling mistakes or verb contractions
  - can't → cannot, doesn't → does not, won't → will not
- Don't mix up British and American English
- A good sentence needs:
  - to be able to stand on its own
  - a subject (do-er)
  - a verb (action) (zelfstandig naamwoord)
  - a finite verb (present or past, singular or plural) (persoonsvorm)
- Show steps in your argument (first, second, last)
- Show relation between bits of information (signaalwoorden)

Academic Style

- Be impersonal and objective
- Deals with question and answers, not just information
- Contains a discussion of previous research
- No informal language (and punctuation)
  - Never use 'you' and mostly avoid 'I' and 'we'
  - Don't use conjunctions (for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so (FANBOYS)) to start a sentence
  - No emotional language
  - Be careful of punctuation (always avoid the ! and avoid ? unless it's your research question)
  - Use a range of reporting verbs
    - Instead of 'say' use: suggests, argues, found, shows, describes and proposes that
  - Avoid words like 'people', because it's really vague

https://www.phrasebank.manchester.ac.uk/

Exercise 2

1. Our bank has told us that you haven't made this month's payment.
   - The bank informed us that the monthly payment has not been transferred.
   - ex. According to communication from the bank, it appears that his month's payment has not yet been received.
2. So, I really think those bosses of international companies don't really care about the law.
   - I believe, the CEO's of international companies do not properly value the law.
   - ex. Therefore, it can be strongly argued that the leadership of multinational corporations does not prioritize legalities.
3. The laws are made because we think they're necessary.

- The laws correspond with our needs.
- ex. Legislation is based upon perceived necessity

4. We couldn't know ahead of time that there would be an economic disaster.
    - The economic disaster could not have been predicted. → good enough

Exercise 1

Playing video games are a well-known form of entertainment, especially among the younger generations. People often spend a significant amount of time per day behind a screens, not acknowledging the harmful effects it has on their brains. Video games can have disguised positive or negative effects on the mind.

7th of April (WG)

Introductions

- Establish the importance of your field
- Provide background facts/information
- Define the terminology in the title/key words
- Present the problem area/current research focus
- Previous and/or current research and contributions
- Locate a gap in the research
- Describe the problem you will address
- Present a prediction to be tested
- Describe the present paper

Assignment 1: three sentences

1. General indication of topic/factual observation
2. Narrowing down to a subtopic
3. Thesis statement
    - it guides the content and structure
    - You could choose between three forms:
        - A question
        - Statement of aims
        - A statement

Error correction